

Perceptual determinants of nonprofit giving behavior

Adrian Sargeant^a, John B. Ford^{b,*}, Douglas C. West^c

^a*Bristol Business School, Bristol, UK*

^b*Department of Business Administration, College of Business and Public Administration, Old Dominion University, Norfolk, VA 23529, United States*

^c*Birmingham Business School, the University of Birmingham, UK*

Received 4 January 2005; accepted 19 April 2005

Abstract

This paper provides the first empirically based marketing model of the perceptions of givers and the resulting impact on donations. Within nonprofit marketing there is a considerable amount of extant research to support the view that both extrinsic and intrinsic variables can be used to separate givers and non-givers to nonprofits. However, they are less useful in explaining the level of support that will be offered. Perceptual factors may offer more utility in this regard. Structural equations models are presented based on a survey of over 1300 donors that link a series of perceptual determinants to the level of the average donation to a specific organization. The potential mediating roles of trust and commitment are also explored. Trust appears unrelated to the direct benefits that accrue to donors as a consequence of their gift. Rather, trust (and indirectly, commitment) is predicated on the perceived benefits supplied to beneficiaries and the manner in which the impact of these benefits is communicated back to donors.

© 2005 Elsevier Inc. All rights reserved.

1. Introduction

This paper builds on the extensive and broad based literature underpinning nonprofit marketing and delineates a group of perceptual factors that might influence individual support of charitable organizations. Its main contribution is to provide the first empirically based marketing model of the perceptions of givers to nonprofits and the resulting impact on donations. The focus is on the individual determinants of giving as a subset of factors that have been postulated to impact on donor behavior (cf., Bendapudi et al., 1996). Thus, factors pertaining to the wider fundraising environment, the fundraising techniques employed and the nature/portrayal of beneficiaries have all been deliberately excluded from our analysis.

Attempts have previously been made to develop a broad perspective on why individuals might give to

voluntary organizations based on synthesizing the literature (see especially Bendapudi et al., 1996; Burnett and Wood, 1988; Guy and Patton, 1989). However there is, as yet, little empirical work on donor perceptions of the recipient organization and the role that these might play in stimulating giving behavior. Equally, previous studies concerned with monetary donations have tended to select the decision to donate or not, as their primary focus (Green and Webb, 1997; Sargeant, 1999), rather than exploring the factors that drive the value of gifts (Schlegelmilch et al., 1992). It also remains unclear the extent to which these factors may impact on giving directly or be mediated through additional constructs such as trust and commitment.

To address these issues this paper begins by summarizing the factors felt to determine individual giving and highlights the need for further research in relation to donor perceptions of recipient organization(s). The following sections explore the likely relationship between these constructs and giving behavior. A model is then developed and its performance empirically tested against a key structural alternative.

* Corresponding author. Tel.: +1 757 683 3587 (Office), +1 757 6230639 (Home); fax: +1 757 683 5639.

E-mail address: jbford@odu.edu (J.B. Ford).

2. Individual determinants of giving

A variety of extrinsic and intrinsic factors can influence giving. In respect of the former, variables such as age (Halfpenny, 1990; Nichols, 1992; Pharoah and Tanner, 1997), gender (Mesch et al., 2002; Chrenka et al., 2003; Hall, 2004), social class (Jones and Posnett, 1991; Bryant et al., 2003; McClelland and Brooks, 2004), social norms (Morgan et al., 1979; Piliavin and Charng, 1990; Radley and Kennedy, 1995) and the degree of religious conviction (Halfpenny, 1990; Pharoah and Tanner, 1997; Jackson, 2001) have all been shown to impact on giving behavior.

The intrinsic determinants of giving are the underlying motives for electing to support a nonprofit (Sargeant, 1999). Factors shown to be significant indicators of giving include empathy (Fultz et al., 1986; Cialdini et al., 1997), sympathy (Clary and Snyder, 1991; Fultz et al., 1986; Schwartz, 1977) and emotions such as fear, guilt and pity (Amos, 1982; Dawson, 1988; Feldman and Feldman, 1985). It has also been argued, from the perspective of social justice motivation theory, that if people witness undue suffering, their belief in a 'just world' will be threatened, and they will be motivated to respond to restore their faith in justice (Lerner, 1975; Miller, 1977).

More recently, a variety of authors have begun to examine the role of the organization soliciting funds and more particularly, how donors perceive distinct facets of the organization or the 'product' on offer. Authors such as Glaser (1994) and Sargeant et al. (2001) have examined how donors perceive the management of the organization, its performance and a variety of benefits that might accrue to the individual from giving. An empirical examination of the impact of these factors has yet to be attempted. This is an issue of considerable practical importance since these are variables over which fundraisers may exert some control. It is, therefore, our intention to delineate the perceptual determinants of the support of nonprofits and to explore the nature of the relationship between these and recorded patterns of giving behavior.

3. Exploratory phase

The first phase of the research was designed to elicit a list of relevant perceptual factors that could then be tested quantitatively to determine their impact on recorded giving behavior. Phase 1 thus began with a review of the literature in conjunction with a series of eight focus groups each containing 8–10 members and stratified by a cross-section of socio-economic group and age. Each group ran for around 90 min and discussions were taped, transcribed and subjected to a content analysis employing QSR NUD*IST. This analysis suggested that two distinct categories of perceptual constructs can impact on giving, namely: (1) perceptions of the benefits (if any) that might accrue from support and (2) perceptions of the behavior of the specific

(i.e. supported) organization. The analysis, moreover, suggested that the impact of these perceptual constructs could be mediated by the additional constructs of trust and commitment. It is important to note that although the focus group data supported a consideration of each of the constructs that emerged from the literature a different perspective on the relationship between these constructs and the mediators of trust and commitment was identified. These differences will be specifically highlighted in the following discussion. In Phase 2 of the research a model based on the extant research will be tested against one supplemented by our focus group data for the purposes of comparison. The two models are provided in Fig. 1A and B, respectively.

Few empirical studies have addressed the role of trust in relation to nonprofit-donor relationships (Sargeant and Lee, 2004), but there is now a wealth of empirical evidence to support the critical role that trust can play in influencing relationships between companies and customers (e.g., Gounans, 2005). These studies conclude that higher levels of trust improve the likelihood that a relationship will be entered into. They also illustrate that where a relationship already exists, higher levels of commitment will be generated by virtue of the presence of trust, and that higher levels of both sales and loyalty will accrue as a consequence (Anderson and Weitz, 1989; Dwyer et al., 1987). In such relationships, trust is viewed as particularly important where intangible services are provided because consumers often lack objective criteria to assess the performance (Coleman, 1990). This has relevance to the voluntary sector where not only is the service provided to donors often highly intangible (Polonsky and Macdonald, 2000) but the service provided to the beneficiary group (as a consequence of a donation) can frequently not be assessed by donors at all. They must rely on the nonprofit to deliver benefits to society that have either been explicitly or implicitly promised (Hansmann, 1980).

Trust, commitment and giving behaviour are related sequentially. Trust refers to the extent of donor belief that a charity will behave as expected and fulfill its obligations (see: Sargeant and Lee, 2004). Commitment, which Moorman et al. (1992, p. 316) define as 'an enduring desire to maintain a valued relationship' is a function of trust. This is a relationship widely supported in the marketing literature and a logical conclusion given that commitment by definition will always involve some degree of self-sacrifice and is unlikely to occur in circumstances where trust is absent. (e.g., Gabarino and Johnson, 1999; Morgan and Hunt, 1994). In the only empirical study of these relationships to be conducted in the voluntary sector context, Sargeant and Lee (2004) provide empirical evidence in the UK in support of this perspective. It is, therefore, hypothesized that:

H1. There is a positive causal link between the degree of commitment and donor giving behaviour.

H2. There is a positive causal link between the degree of trust and the degree of commitment.

4. Perception of benefits

Social Exchange Theory suggests that donors will often be motivated to give because they perceive that some benefits will accrue to them as a consequence of their gift (Amos, 1982; Bar-Tel, 1976; Krebs, 1982). These benefits may be categorized as ‘demonstrable’, ‘emotional’ and ‘familial’. Each one will now be reviewed in turn.

Demonstrable benefits relate to the process of giving as the result of selfish economic considerations. Those who subscribe to this school of thought believe that donors will select nonprofits to support on the basis of whether they have benefited in the past or believe that they will do so in the future (Amos, 1982; Beatty et al., 1991; Frisch and Gerrard, 1981). Donors may also evaluate potential recipient organizations against the extent to which their support will be visible or noticeable by others within their social group, thereby enhancing the donor’s standing (Stroebe and Frey,

1982). Variables such as self-esteem and recognition have often been identified as key motives for giving (Kotler and Andreasen, 1987; Haggberg, 1992; Komter, 1996) with organizations offering donors greater prestige successfully attracting larger donations.

Donors can also obtain utility from a charitable donation because of the emotions experienced in so doing, rather than from any tangible benefits they might receive (Andreoni, 2001). Indeed, many economists now recognize that utility can be afforded through the change in emotions that a particular act evokes. This reflects a view long held in the psychology literature (Bendapudi et al., 1996) and was evidenced in the focus group work conducted in this study. For example one focus group member (hereafter FGM) noted: “I lost my dog to cancer last year. When they [Charity Y] wrote to me for a donation I felt my gift might help save someone else’s pet. I really felt good about that.” This form of response has been widely cited as the utility derived from personal mood management (Cialdini et al.,

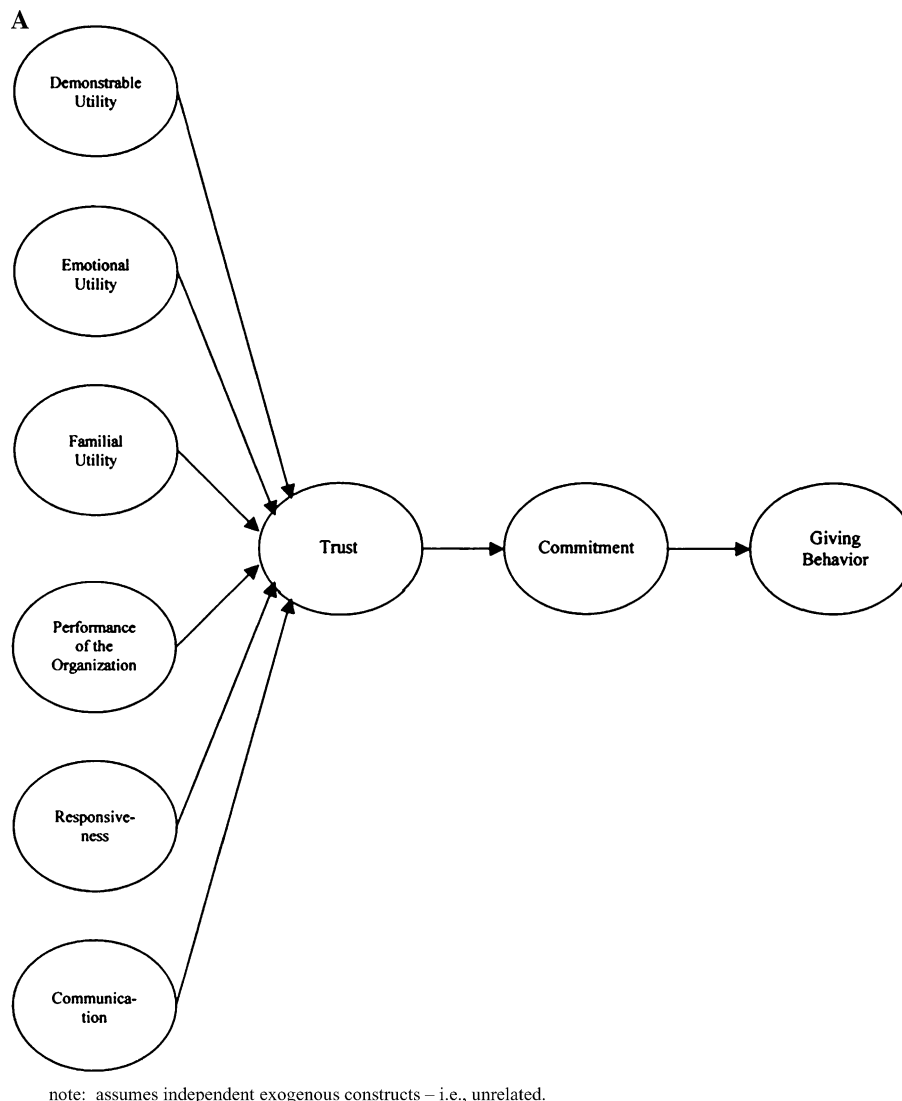


Fig. 1. (A) Literature-based model US charity giving behavior. (B) Focus-group enhanced theoretical model US charity giving behavior.

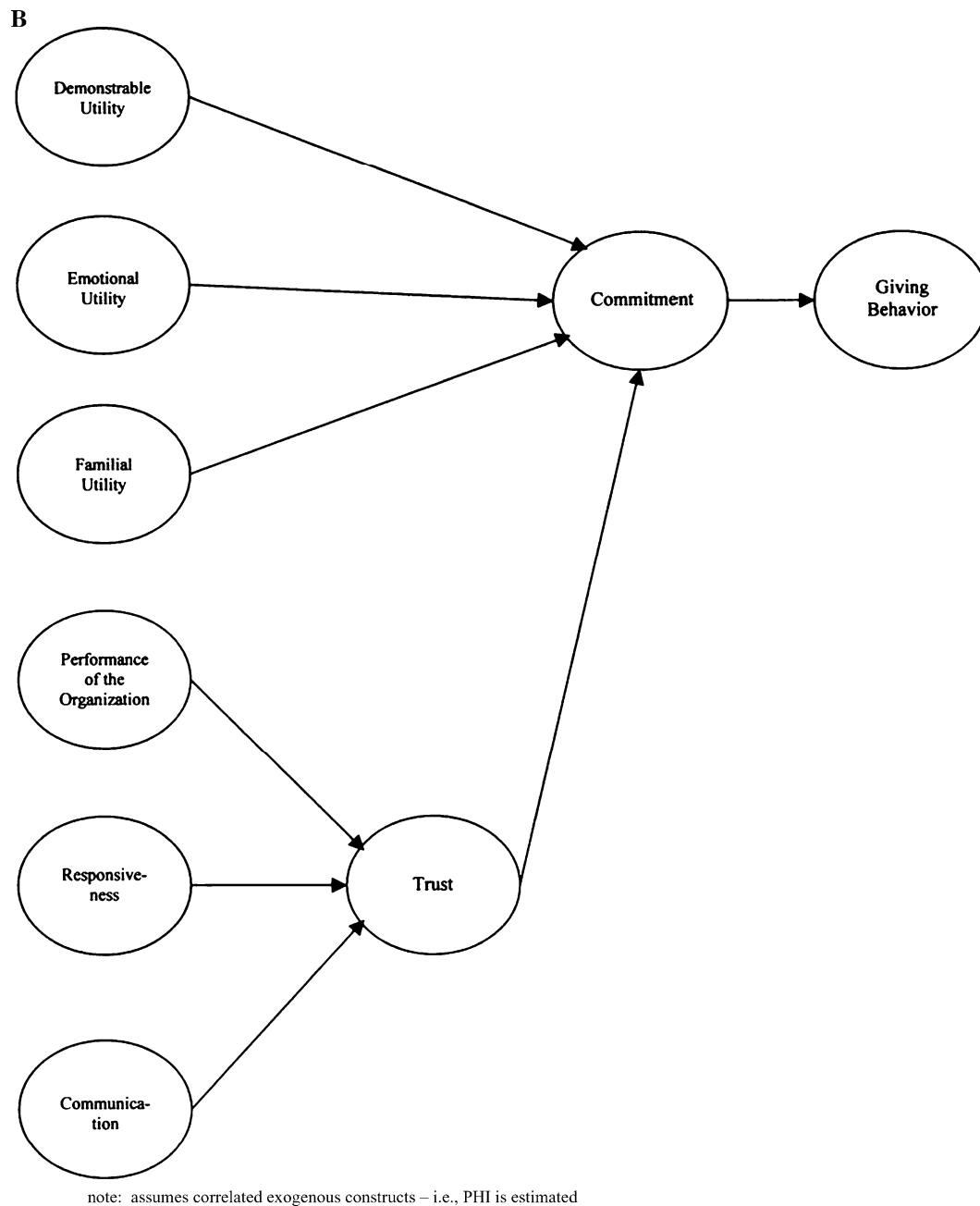


Fig. 1 (continued).

1987; Wegener and Petty, 1994) and referred to here as ‘emotional utility’.

Alternatively, for some donors, the motivation to support a nonprofit derives from the need to assist or demonstrate an affinity with one’s friends or loved ones (Bruce, 1998; Sargeant, 1999): familial utility. Donations to a cancer nonprofit, for example, may be motivated by a perception that the gift might benefit a friend or loved one that suffers from the disease. Take the case of one FGM who stated: “*I lost my Mom to cancer last year. It was so needless when a cure is so close. If I can help bring it closer, that makes me feel*

she didn’t die in vain”. Healthcare organizations, in particular, have long recognized that donations may be motivated by a personal link to a cause, often, in their case, in memoriam (Kotler and Clarke, 1987).

In conceptualizing these three categories of benefit and their relationship with giving, the extant marketing literature suggests that the ability of the nonprofit to supply a particular package of benefits would tend to build trust in, and commitment to, the organization. In particular the seminal work by Morgan and Hunt (1994) specifically tested the relationship between benefits, trust and commit-

ment. In a consumer context, [Bhattacharya et al. \(1995\)](#) found empirical support for such a relationship although [Gabarino and Johnson \(1999\)](#) later suggested that it is necessary to distinguish between consumers looking for a relationship with the organization from those seeking transactions. The relationship postulated above would be supported by the former while the latter would impact directly on behavior. Since this study is concerned with regular givers who receive and respond to communications with the nonprofit organization, rather than donors unknown to the nonprofit who give to sidewalk collectors ('impulse' forms of giving ([Burnett, 1992](#)), extent theory would suggest that trust and commitment would play sequential and mediating roles between donor perceptions and their recorded giving behavior. The following hypotheses are, therefore, offered:

H3a. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived demonstrable utility and donor giving behavior mediated by trust and commitment.

H4a. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived emotional utility and donor giving behavior mediated by trust and commitment.

H5a. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived familial utility and donor giving behavior mediated by trust and commitment.

Nevertheless, the analysis of FGM data did not support the above relationship. Rather, it was clear that donors felt the perceived benefits of their association with the nonprofit directly influenced the level of commitment they felt to the organization. Here are some illustrative quotes:

- *'I'll support them for as long as they keep sending me the (In House Magazine). We get many useful tips on how to cope with Mary's condition. When we receive it, it reminds me of why I support them and yes, if they ask I'll offer them another donation.'*
- *I don't really care about how they treat me. When you lose someone to cancer you get real committed to the organization and the work it does.*
- *I give to (the organization) because it makes me feel good. Helping kids does, doesn't it? I care about them and the work that's done with them, that's why I've been supporting (the organization).*

Given the disparity between the conclusions of the analysis of focus group data and extant theory, an alternative perspective will be tested on the relationship between perceived benefits, trust and commitment:

H3b. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived demonstrable utility and commitment.

H4b. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived emotional utility and commitment.

H5b. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived familial utility and commitment.

5. Organizational factors

Three distinct factors were identified namely the performance of the organization, responsiveness and communication. Each of which is briefly outlined below.

When it comes to performance of the organization, [Tonkiss and Passey \(1999\)](#) have argued that the extent to which a potential donor has 'trust' will be driven by the extent to which they believe the organizations has demonstrated it will use donations wisely. This view was supported in the focus group discussions. For example, one FGM stated: *"I've heard that a lot of nonprofits spend too much on salaries for the staff."* Another added: *"They [nonprofits] should spend less on fundraising and sending out all that mail. They must be wasting a fortune on all these materials."*

Focus group data further suggested that the responsiveness of the communications of organization would drive trust and hence giving. As one FGM said: *"One time—I sent them a check for \$1000. It took them two months to reply. I never sent them anything again. Would you trust them after that?"* There is little empirical support for this proposition in extant studies, but it has been suggested that higher value donors place greater emphasis on an organization's perceived responsiveness to their needs ([Burlingame, 1997](#); [Sargeant and MacKenzie, 1998](#)).

Communications emerged as the third theme from the focus group analysis. It emerged that the perceptions of the quality of information provided and the overall presentation of the campaign materials received were important issues for donors. As noted by one FGM: *'I only ever give once a year—they know that—yet for the past five years they have continued to write to me six times a year. I don't think they really know what they're doing'.* Work by [Schlegelmilch et al. \(1992\)](#) and [Greenfield \(1996\)](#) has confirmed that the perceived quality of communication can impact on giving, but the data suggests that this may again be mediated through the construct of trust, as the following quotation illustrates. *'I don't really know much about how my money is being used. I don't think they've ever told me, not made it personal like. They just keep on asking for more. I'm sure I'd trust them more if they did let me know and (would) probably give more too.'*

The following final hypotheses are, therefore, suggested:

H6. There is a positive causal link between the perceived performance of a nonprofit and trust in that organization.

H7. There is a positive causal link between the degree of perceived responsiveness of a nonprofit organization and donor trust in the organization.

H8. There is a positive causal link between the perception a donor might have of fundraising communications from a nonprofit organization and donor trust in that organization.

6. Method

6.1. Scale development

Phase 2 of the research comprised identifying appropriate scales to measure the constructs. Commitment was straightforward as after considerable review it was decided that an adaptation of the scale developed by [Morgan and Hunt \(1994\)](#) was appropriate to this context. During the pre-test an acceptable alpha of 0.89 was obtained for the scale. Similarly it was possible to employ the trust scale developed by [Sargeant and Lee \(2004\)](#) specifically in the fundraising context and an acceptable alpha was recorded in the pre-test of 0.96. In measuring the remaining 6 perceptual constructs noted above, the procedures recommended by [Churchill \(1979\)](#) were followed. A review of the pertinent literature suggested an appropriate pool of 50 items to measure the constructs. This item pool was then subject to scrutiny by a panel of judges. Each judge was provided with a definition of each construct and asked to categorize each item according to these definitions. Following [Pritchard et al. \(1999\)](#), panel members were also required to appraise each item for its appropriateness and clarity on a measurement scale from 1 to 5. A consensus in respect of categorization, fit and clarity ratings (i.e. 4 or above) was sufficient to admit items to the final item pool in each case. This process concluded with the retention of 42 items. Five point numeric bipolar scales ranging from 1=strongly disagree to 5=strongly agree were then attached to each statement.

A convenience sample was chosen for the purposes of scale purification comprising of 1000 individuals working in three public institutions in a large mid-Western city who had given to nonprofits. Questionnaires were distributed by managers and returned to a central point for collection and processing. Subsequent analysis revealed 25 questionnaires that were incomplete or unusable, resulting in final sample of size of 975.

Scale purification procedures were then applied to the scales. Survey responses were split into two halves to cross validate any decisions that might be made in respect of item reduction ([Pritchard et al., 1999](#)). The procedure began with an analysis of alpha coefficients for each set of attitudinal statements. It was decided to eliminate items which improved corresponding alpha scores to the point where all retained items had corrected item to total correlations greater than 0.4 (cf., [Zachowsky, 1985](#)). This process was cross-validated between samples and items common to both split samples were retained, resulting in a pool of 30. Each set of items was then subject to an exploratory factor analysis (principal axis factoring with a VARIMAX rotation). Cattel's scree test indicated that 6 factor solutions

were preferable in each case. Factor structures appeared consistent, although a number of mixed item themes initially emerged. To eliminate this issue a further reduction of scale items was undertaken and the analysis repeated. A common core of 26 items was generated.

Finally, both samples were combined to re-examine internal homogeneity. It proved necessary to remove a further 2 items. The remaining 24 statements were then subjected to a further principal axis factoring with the solution restricted to 6 factors in each case. Eigenvalues of greater than 1 were recorded for each factor and no cross loadings were reported. Reliability for each of the 6 separate scales was assessed utilizing Cronbach Alpha Coefficients, and all were above the minimum level of 0.70. The refined scales for each of the constructs are presented in Appendix A. It should be noted that Emotional Utility and Performance of the Organization both include only two items. These two constructs are under identified and even though the inter-item correlations are high, it is worth noting that

Table 1
Comparison of structural equations models

Path	Model A (literature-based)	Model B (focus-group enhanced)
<i>Direct effects</i>		
DU→CM		0.00
EU→CM		0.17**
FU→CM		0.57**
DU→T	0.04	
EU→T	0.17**	
FU→T	0.21**	
PO→T	0.22**	0.26**
R→T	−0.01	−0.06
C→T	0.06	0.15**
T→CM	0.49**	0.33**
CM→ACG	0.40**	0.36**
<i>Squared correlations</i>		
T	0.19**	0.10**
CM	0.24**	0.50**
ACG	0.16**	0.13**
<i>Model fit</i>		
X ² (df)	1253.06 (384)	917 (365)
NFI	0.856	0.905
RFI	0.826	0.894
IFI	0.896	0.944
TLI	0.873	0.936
CFI	0.895	0.943
RMSEA	0.064	0.049
PRATIO	0.826	0.839
PNFI	0.707	0.747
PCFI	0.739	0.781
AIC	1488.22	928.00
BCC	1048.68	981.13
Performance Rank	2	1

DU=Demonstrable Utility; EU=Emotional Utility; FU=Familial Utility; PO=Performance of the Organization; R=Responsiveness; C=Communication; T=Trust; CM=Commitment; ACG=Average gift to the charity in question; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.010$.

construct scales should contain at least three or four items to be properly identified. The correlation matrix for the various latent study constructs is shown in Appendix A.1.

Phase 3 of the research set out to test the models depicted in Fig. 1A and B. Data were obtained from a six-page mail questionnaire sent to 4000 donors. A sample of 500 individuals was selected from the databases of 8 national, well-known and leading nonprofits, representing a diverse range of causes (e.g. religion, conservation, animal welfare, need within the Hispanic community). After one mailing 1355 replies were returned, providing a usable response rate

of 33.9%. It was not possible to assess the extent of non-response bias (Chen, 1996) with respect to primary demographics (e.g., gender, age and employment) owing to the random method of sample selection and the low level of information held on the nonprofit databases. However, giving histories (drawn from the nonprofit databases) were matched *post hoc* to questionnaire responses making it possible to calculate the mean gift offered to the organization in question.

All construct scales used in the modeling were then subjected to Confirmatory Factor Analysis using AMOS

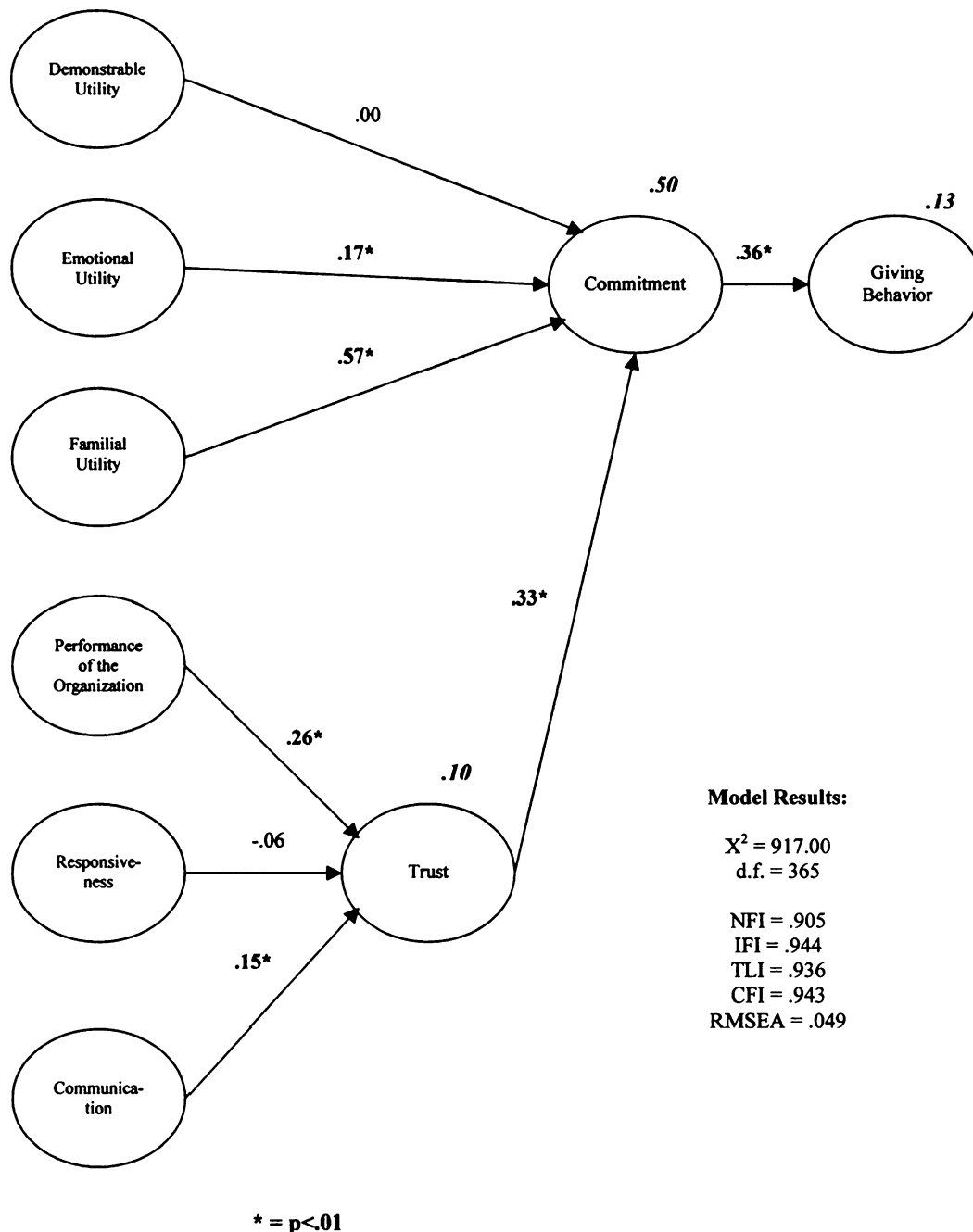


Fig. 2. Focus-group enhanced theoretical model US charity giving behavior.

5.0. The six perceptual scales that were developed and refined were comprised of the 24 items previously discussed in this section, and these were analysed along with the two previously validated scales for Trust and Commitment, which were adapted for use in a charitable giving context. The only other measure utilized in the model was an observable measurement variable (average charity gift); it was, therefore, not included in the Confirmatory Factor Analysis. This produced eight constructs with 32 total items for assessment. These constructs were all assumed to be inter-correlated for the purposes of the CFA. The Confirmatory Factor Analysis (Chi Square=679.5 with 437 degrees of freedom) showed good fit with IFI=0.972 and CFI=0.971 and an RMSEA of 0.035. An examination of the modification indices and standardized residuals suggested that there were no major sources of error in the final model.

7. Findings

7.1. Structural equations models

As the primary purpose of this research is to explain donor giving behaviour, the two models were then compared to determine which had the better fit and explanatory power. Once the better model is determined, then the hypotheses can be tested by assessing the various linkages in the SEM.

In a comparison of the two models, all fit measures were superior for Model B (see Table 1). The Chi Square statistic for Model B was 917.00 with 365 degrees of freedom as opposed to 1253.06 with 384 degrees of freedom for Model A. In terms of specific fit measures, Model B had a CFI measure of 0.943 as opposed to 0.895 for Model A. The RMSEA for Model B was 0.049 as opposed to 0.064 for Model A. As a result, Model B was determined to be the appropriate model for hypothesis testing purposes.

7.2. Testing of the hypotheses

Having determined that model B is the appropriate model for explaining giving behaviour, the model results are now employed to test the various hypotheses. The model, the squared correlations for the key study constructs, and the standardized path coefficients are shown in Fig. 2. H1 examined the impact of commitment upon giving behaviour, and the path coefficient was found to be significant at 0.36 ($p < 0.01$). There is a significant positive causal link between the degree of commitment and donor giving behavior (as measured by the average donation). H2 examined the relationship between trust and commitment. The hypothesis was supported as there was a significant positive causal link (0.33, $p < 0.01$) shown between the degree of trust in the charitable organization and the degree of commitment to the charitable organization.

H3a, H4a and H5a pertain solely to the model driven from the literature, but this model was found to be inferior to the focus group enhanced model. Consequently, these hypotheses were dropped in favor of the alternative hypotheses 3b, H4b and H5b, which examined the links between demonstrable utility, emotional utility, familial utility and commitment. While there was support found for H4b (0.17, $p < 0.01$) and H5b (0.57, $p < 0.01$), there was no support for H3b (0.00). Significant positive causal links were identified between emotional/familial utility and commitment, but there was no causal link identified for demonstrable utility.

H6, H7 and H8 all focused on the various drivers of trust. H6 posited a significant positive causal link between performance of the organization and trust, and the link was found to be significant (0.26, $p < 0.01$). H7 examined the causal link between the responsiveness of the organization and trust, and in this case there was no significant correlation found (−0.06) and so the hypothesis was not supported. Finally, it was posited that communications from the organization would have a significant positive causal link to trust in the organization, and the linkage was positive and significant (0.15, $p < 0.01$). H8 was supported.

8. Discussion

As the model enhanced by our focus groups was found to be superior, it is necessary to discuss the various model linkages and what they mean. Trust appears to be significantly affected by the performance of the charity and its communication, but not by its responsiveness. Trust is created when a nonprofit is perceived to have had an impact on the cause and by maintaining appropriate communications with the donor rather than by responding quickly to particular issues or concerns.

The results also indicate that emotional utility and familial utility are of similar importance to trust in driving commitment. Where giving makes a donor feel good about themselves and where there is a family connection to the cause, it would appear that individual bonds to the organization are strengthened. The model suggests that this is best viewed as a direct effect rather than mediated through trust. Indeed commitment may develop in the absence of trust where giving is motivated by a need to mitigate emotional distress or as an expression of familial ties to the organization.

No support was found for the hypothesized role of demonstrable utility. The extent to which a nonprofit is capable of providing personal benefits for its donors seems to drive neither commitment nor trust in the organization. It is, of course, entirely possible that perceived individual benefits may play a role in stimulating giving (i.e. persuading a non-donor to become a donor) but no evidence was found that once this has

taken place, that benefits impact on either of the relationship variables tested here.

The final relationship tested was between commitment and giving behavior measured by the level of the average gift. This relationship was positively supported, although it is important to note that the proportion of giving behavior explained by commitment is relatively modest. This was a finding very much in line with our expectations since demographics remain the primary drivers of how much an individual will be willing and able to donate.

9. Conclusions and further research

The roles played by trust and commitment in the voluntary sector appear somewhat different to those previously identified in the commercial context. Critically, trust appears unrelated to the direct benefits that accrue to donors as a consequence of their gift. Rather, trust (and indirectly, commitment) is predicated on the perceived benefits supplied to beneficiaries and the manner in which the impact of these benefits is communicated back to donors. Furthermore, the sequential dependency of commitment on trust found in the for-profit sector has not been fully replicated. Trust was found to be important, but emotional and familial utilities are similarly significant when it comes to fostering donor commitment. Feeling good about a donation to a particular charity appears to enhance commitment beyond any existing levels of trust and if there is a family bond the effect is even greater. Trust has no mediating effect here. Further research would be necessary to identify why this would be the case, but it is possible that emotional utility and familial utility build commitment to the *cause* rather than to the specific organization. The nonprofit may be a vehicle for expression and hence the relationship dynamics, commonly observed in the wider service sector, do not apply. These are important issues for subsequent research given the observation in our findings that average gifts do rise as commitment increases. Additional research could also be conducted in the context of specific causes to determine whether the perceptual determinants, or the role of particular determinants might vary by context. There is also a need to replicate our work in other geographical contexts as the manner in which the voluntary sector seeks to fundraise or the nature of the nonprofits comprising the sector may vary substantially from one country to another.

Acknowledgements

We would like to thank the Aspen Institute and the Indiana University Foundation for their generous financial support of this research.

Appendix A. Construct scale items

Perception of Benefits	Data items
<i>Demonstrable Utility (DU)</i>	
1. When I give to this nonprofit I receive some benefit in return for my donation	Statement 1
2. I give to this nonprofit to gain local prestige	Statement 2
3. I donate money to this nonprofit to receive their publications	Statement 3
4. Contributing to this nonprofit enables me to obtain recognition	Statement 4
5. I may one day benefit from the work this organization undertakes	Statement 5
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.710
<i>Emotional Utility (EU)</i>	
1. I often give to this nonprofit because I would feel guilty if I didn't	Statement 6
2. If I never gave to this nonprofit I would feel bad about myself	Statement 7
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.684
<i>Familial Utility (FU)</i>	
1. I give money to this nonprofit in memory of a loved one	Statement 8
2. I felt that someone I know might benefit from my support	Statement 9
3. My family had a strong link to this nonprofit	Statement 10
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.729
<i>Performance of the Organization (PO)</i>	
1. This nonprofit is the nonprofit most likely to have an impact on this cause	Statement 11
2. This nonprofit spends a high proportion of its income on this cause	Statement 12
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.831
<i>Responsiveness of the Organization (RO)</i>	
1. This nonprofit always responds promptly to requests I might have for information	Statement 13
2. Employees at this nonprofit are never too busy to speak with me	Statement 14
3. Employees in this nonprofit are always courteous	Statement 15
4. Employees in this nonprofit have the knowledge to answer your questions	Statement 16
5. This nonprofit gives you individual attention	Statement 17
6. When I have a problem, this nonprofit shows an interest in solving it	Statement 18
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.883
<i>Communication Quality (CQ)</i>	
1. This nonprofit's communications make me confident it is using my monies appropriately	Statement 19
2. This nonprofit keeps me informed about how my monies are being used	Statement 20
3. I look forward to receiving communications from this organization	Statement 21
4. I feel safe in my transactions with this nonprofit	Statement 22
5. This nonprofit's communications are always courteous	Statement 23
6. This nonprofit's communications are always timely	Statement 24
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.844
<i>Commitment (C)</i>	
1. I feel a sense of belonging to this organization	Statement 25
2. I care about the long term success of this organization	Statement 26

Appendix A (continued)

Commitment (C)

3. I would describe myself as a loyal supporter of this organization	Statement 27
4. I will be giving more to this nonprofit next year	Statement 28
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.761

Trust (T)

1. I would trust this nonprofit to always act in the best interest of the cause	Statement 29
2. I would trust this nonprofit to conduct their operations ethically	Statement 30
3. I would trust this nonprofit to use donated funds appropriately	Statement 31
4. I would trust this nonprofit not to exploit their donors	Statement 32
5. I would trust this nonprofit to use fundraising techniques that are appropriate and sensitive	Statement 33
Reliability (Cronbach Alpha Coefficient)	0.942

A.1. Correlation matrix for latent study constructs

	DU	EU	FU	PO	RO	CQ	C	T
Demonstrable Utility (DU)	1.00							
Emotional Utility (EU)	0.354	1.00						
Familial Utility (FU)	0.103	0.224	1.00					
Performance of the Organization (PO)	0.075	0.062	0.228	1.00				
Responsiveness of the Organization (RO)	−0.053	0.090	0.160	0.210	1.00			
Communication Quality (CQ)	0.011	0.135	0.229	0.251	0.714	1.00		
Commitment (C)	0.100	0.238	0.652	0.248	0.204	0.295	1.00	
Trust (T)	0.110	0.197	0.367	0.312	0.146	0.217	0.418	1.00

References

- Amos OM. Empirical analysis of motives underlying contributions to charity. *Atl Econ J* 1982;10:45–52.
- Anderson E, Weitz BA. Determinants of continuity in conventional industrial channel dyads. *Mark Sci* 1989;8:310–23 [Fall].
- Andreoni J. The economics of philanthropy. In: Smelser NJ, Baltes PB, editors. *International encyclopedia of the social and behavioural sciences*. London: Elsevier; 2001.
- Bar-Tel D. *Prosocial behavior: theory and research*. New York, NY: John Wiley and Sons, Inc; 1976.
- Beatty SE, Kahle LR, Homer P. Personal values and gift giving behaviors: a study across cultures. *J Bus Res* 1991;22:149–57.
- Bendapudi N, Singh SN, Bendapudi V. Enhancing helping behavior: an integrative framework for promotion planning. *J Mark* 1996;60(3): 33–49.
- Bhattacharya CB, Rao H, Glynn MA. Understanding the bond of identification: an investigation of its correlates among art museum members. *J Mark* 1995;59:46–57 (October).
- Bruce I. *Successful charity marketing: marketing need*. Hemel Hempstead, UK: ICSA Publishing; 1998.
- Bryant WK, Jeon-Slaughter H, Kang H, Tax A. Participation in philanthropic activities: donating money and time. *J Consum Policy* 2003;26(1):43–74.
- Burlingame DF. *Critical issues in fund raising*. New York, NY: NSFRE/Wiley; 1997.
- Burnett K. *Relationship fundraising*. London: White Lion Press; 1992.
- Burnett JJ, Wood VR. A proposed model of the donation process. *Res Consum Behav* 1988;3:1–47.
- Chen HCK. Direction, magnitude and implications of non-response bias in mail surveys. *J Mark Res Soc* 1996;38(3):267–77.
- Chrenka J, Gutter MS, Jasper C. Gender differences in the decision to give time or money. *Consum Interests Annu* 2003;49:1–5.
- Churchill GA. A paradigm for developing better measures of marketing constructs. *J Mark Res* 1979;16:64–73.
- Cialdini RB, Arps K, Fultz F, Beaman A. Empathy based helping: is it selfishly or selflessly motivated? *J Pers Soc Psychol* 1987;52: 749–758.
- Cialdini RB, Brown SL, Lewis BP, Luce C, Neuberg SL. Reinterpreting the empathy-altruism relationship: When one into one equals oneness. *J Pers Soc Psychol* 1997;73(3):481–95.
- Clary EG, Snyder M. A functional analysis of altruism and pro-social behavior: the case of volunteerism. *Rev Person Soc Psychol* 1991;12:119–48.
- Coleman JS. *Foundations of social theory*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press; 1990.
- Dawson S. Four motivations for charitable giving: implications for marketing strategy to attract monetary donations for medical research. *J Health Care Mark* 1988;31–7 [June 8].
- Dwyer FR, Schurr PH, Oh S. Developing buyer–seller relationships. *J Mark* 1987;51:11–27 [April].
- Feldman D, Feldman B. The effect of a telethon on attitudes toward disabled people and financial contributions. *J Rehabil* 1985;51:42–5.
- Frisch M, Gerrard M. Natural helping systems: a survey of red cross volunteers. *Am J Community Psychol* 1981;9:567–79.
- Fultz JC, Batson D, Fortenbach VA, McCarthy P, Varney LL. Social evaluation and the empathy altruism hypothesis. *J Pers Soc Psychol* 1986;50:761–9.
- Gabarino E, Johnson MS. The different roles of satisfaction, trust and commitment in customer relationships. *J Mark* 1999;63:70–87 [April].
- Glaser JS. *The united way scandal—An insider's account of what went wrong and why*. New York, NY: John Wiley and Sons; 1994.
- Gounans SP. Trust and commitment influences on customer retention: insights from business-to-business services. *J Bus Res* 2005;58(2): 126–41.
- Green CL, Webb DJ. Factors influencing monetary donations to charitable organizations. *J Nonprofit Public Sect Mark* 1997;5(3):19–40.
- Greenfield JM. *Fundraising cost effectiveness: a self-assessment workbook*. New York, NY: John Wiley and Sons; 1996.
- Guy BS, Patton WE. The marketing of altruistic causes: understanding why people help. *J Serv Mark* 1989;2(1):5–16.
- Hagberg M. Why donors give. *Fund Rais Manag* 1992;23(2):39–40.
- Halfpenny P. *Charity household survey 1988/9*. Tonbridge, UK: Charities Aid Foundation; 1990.
- Hall H. Gender differences in giving: going, going gone? *New Dir Philanthr Fundrais* 2004;43:71–2.
- Hansmann H. The role of the nonprofit enterprise. *Yale Law Rev* 1980; 89:835–99 [April].
- Jackson TD. Young African Americans: A new generation of giving behavior. *Int J Nonprofit Volunt Sect Mark* 2001;6(3):243–54.
- Jones A, Posnett J. Charitable giving by UK households: evidence from the family expenditure survey. *Appl Econ* 1991;23:343–51.
- Komter AE. Reciprocity as a principle of exclusion: Gift giving in the Netherlands. *Sociology* 1996;30(2):299–317.
- Kotler P, Andreasen A. *Strategic marketing for nonprofit organizations*. 3rd ed. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall; 1987.
- Kotler P, Clarke RN. *Marketing for health care organizations*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall; 1987.

- Krebs D. Altruism—A Rational Approach. In: Eisenberg N, editor. *The development of prosocial behaviour*. New York: Academic Press; 1982. p. 53–77.
- Lerner MJ. The justice motive in social behavior. *J Soc Issues* 1975;31: 1–20.
- McClelland R, Brooks AC. What is the real relationship between income and charitable giving? *Public Finance Rev* 2004;32(5):483–98.
- Mesch DJ, Rooney PM, Chin W, Steinberg KS. Race and gender differences in philanthropy: Indiana as a test case. *New Dir Philanthr Fundrais* (37):65–78.
- Miller DT. Altruism and threat to a belief in a just world. *J Exp Psychol* 1977;13:113–24.
- Moorman C, Zaltman G, Deshpande R. Relationships between providers and users of market research. *J Mark Res* 1992;29(2):82–104.
- Morgan RM, Hunt SD. The commitment–trust theory of relationship building. *J Mark* 1994;58:20–38 [July].
- Morgan JN, Dye RF, Hybels JH. *Results from two national surveys of philanthropic activity*. Ann Arbor, MI: University of Michigan Press; 1979.
- Nichols JE. Targeting older America. *Fund Rais Manag* 1992;23(3): 38–41.
- Pharoah C, Tanner S. Trends in charitable giving. *Fisc Stud* 1997; 18(4):427–43.
- Piliavin JA, Charng HW. Altruism: A review of recent theory and research. *Annu Rev Sociology* 1990;16(1):27–66.
- Polonsky MJ, Macdonald EK. Exploring the link between cause related marketing and brand building. *Int J Nonprofit Volunt Sect Mark* 2000; 5(1):46–57.
- Pritchard MP, Havitz ME, Howard DR. Analyzing the commitment–loyalty link in service contexts. *J Acad Mark Sci* 1999;27(3):333–48.
- Radley A, Kennedy M. Charitable giving by individuals: a study of attitudes and practice. *Hum Relat* 1995;48(6):685–709.
- Sargeant A. Charity giving: towards a model of donor behaviour. *J Market Manag* 1999;15:215–38.
- Sargeant A, Lee S. Donor trust and relationship commitment in the UK charity sector: the impact on behavior. *Nonprofit Volunt Sect Q* 2004; 33(2):185–202.
- Sargeant A, MacKenzie J. *A lifetime of giving*. West Malling, UK: Charities Aid Foundation; 1998.
- Sargeant A, West DC, Ford JB. The role of perceptions in predicting donor value. *J Market Manag* 2001;17:407–28.
- Schlegelmilch BB, Diamantopoulos A, Love A. Determinants of charity giving. Marketing theory and applications: American Marketing Association Winter Conference. In: Allen CT, editor. Chicago, IL: American Marketing Association; 1992. p. 507–16.
- Schwartz S. Normative influences on altruism. In: Berkowitz L, editor. *Advances in experimental social psychology*. New York, NY: Academic Press; 1977. p. 221–79.
- Stroebe W, Frey BS. Self-interest and collective action: the economics and psychology of public goods. *Br J Soc Psychol* 1982;21:121–37.
- Tonkiss F, Passey A. Trust, confidence and voluntary organizations: between values and institutions. *Sociology* 1999;33(2):257–74.
- Wegener DT, Petty RE. Mood management across affective states: the hedonic contingency hypothesis. *J Pers Soc Psychol* 1994;66(6):1034–49.
- Zaichowsky JL. Measuring the involvement construct. *J Consum Res* 1985; 12:341–52 [Dec].